

READING MATERIALS: KENYA AND ITS EDUCATION SYSTEM

Overview of Kenya

Kenya is a country in East Africa that is around 580,000 km² and is on the Indian Ocean along the Equator. Its capital is Nairobi, and it shares borders with Somalia, Ethiopia, Uganda, Tanzania, and South Sudan. There are more than forty different ethnic groups in the population, as well as roughly 2% of Indian, European, and Arab immigrants. Most of the people are Christian, but there are also large Muslim and Hindu communities. Kenya is now divided into 47 counties since the 2010 constitution. The national slogan “harambee,” which means “pulling together,” embodies a heritage of working together as a community that has led to various local development projects, including education.

Kenya gained independence from Britain in 1963. It is a multilingual society with each of the roughly 43 ethnic groups having its own language, but Kiswahili and English serve as the country’s official and national languages.

Economy and Society

Kenya is the most advanced economy in Eastern Africa in terms of regional capacity and a wide range of services, but industry only makes up a small part of the country’s output (around 15–18% of GDP, with manufacturing making up about 6–8%). Agriculture is still the mainstay of the economy, making up around 20–22% of GDP, providing jobs for about 40–45% of the working population, and supporting more than 70% of the rural population. It also brings in nearly half of Kenya’s export profits.

Tourism is still a big source of foreign exchange, bringing in about 8–10% of GDP when both direct and indirect effects are considered. Kenya has a lot of people living in rural areas, but recent demographic trends reveal that more and more people are moving to cities. About 25–30% of the population now resides in cities, which means that about 70–75% of them still live in rural areas and many of them depend on smallholder farming and raising livestock. Kenya’s GDP growth has picked up again since the early 2010s, returning to the mid-single digits in 2022–2023 (around 5–6% in 2023).

Politics and Governance

Kenya has been a democracy for a long time and has generally had stable politics. The country is home to many international organizations and is an

active member of regional and global groups like the East African Community (EAC), African Union (AU), United Nations (UN), Commonwealth, Inter Governmental Authority on Development (IGAD), and Common Market for Eastern and Southern Africa (COMESA).

History of Education in Kenya

Christian missionaries brought formal education to Kenya. They linked schooling to Christianity and the demands of the colonial government. The system that grew up was divided by race and class, with different types and levels of education available to different groups.

From Sessional Paper No. 10 (1965) to the Gachathi report (1976), Mackay (1981), Kamunge (1988), and Koech (1999) reports, Kenya's education system has been molded by a series of commissions and policy papers. More recent influences include Sessional Paper No. 1 from 2005, Vision 2030, and reviews related to the introduction of the Competency Based Curriculum (CBC). High-level task groups, such as the Presidential Working Party led by Prof. Munavu (the Munavu report, 2023), have worked on making the curriculum, assessments, teacher training, TVET links, funding, and county implementation all work together to make learning more relevant, inclusive, and effective.

National Goals of Education

The educational outcomes of education today are summarized in the eight national goals of education:

1. Foster nationalism and patriotism and promote national unity.
2. Promote the social, economic, technological, and industrial needs for national development.
3. Promote individual development and self-fulfillment.
4. Promote sound moral and religious values.
5. Promote social equality and responsibility.
6. Promote respect for and development of Kenya's rich and varied cultures.
7. Promote international consciousness and foster positive attitudes toward other nations.

8. Promote positive attitudes toward good health and environmental protection.

Vision and Mission

Kenya's education sector wants to provide "globally competitive quality education, training, and science, technology, and innovation (STI) for the national production systems and processes for sustainable development."

The sector's objective is "to provide, promote, and coordinate quality education, training, and integration of science, technology, and innovation into the national production systems for sustainable national development."

Structure of Education Systems

Kenya used the 8-4-4 system until 2019, consisting of 8 years of elementary school, 4 years of secondary school, and 4+ years of university. It was launched in 1985 to promote "education for self-reliance."

The Competency Based Curriculum (CBC), now called Competence Based Education (CBE), is being phased in as the 8-4-4 system is phased out. Both systems are currently in use during this transition.

Governance and Administration

The Constitution of Kenya sets up a two-tier structure for running schools:

- **National Government:** In charge of higher education, national policy, and standards.
- **County Governments:** In charge of TVET and early childhood development.

The Ministry of Education is responsible for making and carrying out policies and programs, working with semi-autonomous bodies and the Teachers Service Commission (TSC). Operations are split among regions, counties, and sub-counties, with boards and councils running the institutions.

Competency Based Education (CBE)

Kenya adopted CBE after evaluation of the 8-4-4 curriculum and work by task groups from 2011 to 2013, aligning education with the 2010 Constitution and Vision 2030. CBE, starting in 2019 and concluding in 2028, covers pre-primary to Grade 12. It focuses on inquiry-based learning, critical thinking, problem-solving, creativity, digital literacy, and applicable skills.

Stages of Learning in CBE

CBE divides learning into four stages:

- **Pre-primary (PP1–PP2):** Focuses on broad learning areas like language and math activities, creative and environmental play, religious activities, and pastoral care. Emphasis is on play-based literacy, numeracy readiness, and motor skills.
- **Lower primary (Grades 1–3):** Focuses on seven learning areas: language (English, Kiswahili, or local), math, environmental activities, creative arts, religious education, life skills, and pastoral programs.
- **Upper primary (Grades 4–6):** Builds on basics and adds subjects like science and technology, social studies, and practical subjects like home science or agriculture.
- **Junior secondary (Grades 7–9):** Broadens subject exposure to prepare for specialization, including sciences, history, geography, business studies, ICT, and vocational options.
- **Senior secondary (Grades 10–12):** Allows for specialization in science, humanities, languages, business, or technical/vocational clusters to prepare for national exams and the workforce.

Assessment and Examinations

The Kenya National Examinations Council (KNEC) oversees three main types of tests:

- **KCSE:** The Kenya Certificate of Secondary Education remains the high-stakes test at the end of secondary school.
- **KPSEA:** The Kenya Primary School Education Assessment has replaced the KCPE (which ended in 2023) for Grade 6 students to transition to Junior Secondary School.
- **School-based assessments:** Part of the CBC's ongoing evaluation, focusing on practical skills and progress rather than rote memorization.

Future Outlook

Over the next three to five years, Kenya's education system aims for quality, inclusivity, and resilience. Key priorities include digital reforms, reliable

county-level funding, better implementation skills, and contingency plans for teacher staffing and other risks.